

IDEA VALIDATION WORKSHEET

Answer these with Claude, ChatGPT, etc. before you start writing your business plan.

1. The Idea, In One Line

My idea:

2. Problem Validation

- What problem is this actually solving? Is it real and painful enough that people would pay to fix it?
- Who exactly has this problem? Describe one specific, real person — not a vague category.
- What are people doing today to solve this without my product? Why might that already be good enough?

3. Market Reality Check

- Is this market growing, shrinking, or flat? What evidence tells me that?
- Who are the existing players — direct and indirect? Why hasn't one of them solved this already?
- What would have to be true about this market for my idea to become a real business?

4. Stress-Test the Idea

- What are the three most likely reasons this idea fails? (Ask Claude to be blunt, not encouraging.)
- If a skeptical investor heard this idea for 30 seconds, what's their first objection?
- What's the riskiest assumption this depends on — the one thing that, if wrong, kills the whole idea?

5. Business Model

- What are 2–3 plausible ways this idea could make money? What are the tradeoffs of each?
- Does this need to be a standalone business, or could it be a feature of something that already exists?

6. Cheapest Way to Test It

- What's the fastest, cheapest way to find out if anyone actually wants this — before writing a full plan?
- What should I ask potential customers, and what answers would tell me to stop or keep going?

7. Go / No-Go

- Based on everything above, give me an honest one-paragraph gut-check: is this worth a full business plan, or does it need to change first?

My decision:

What needs to change (if anything):
